Judith Weston

Directing Actors



Creating Memorable Performances *for* Film and Television

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25th Anniversary Edition

Judith Weston

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mw@mwp.com
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Table of Contents

PREFACE TO 25TH ANNIVERSARY EDITION xiv
What's New and Different from the Original xvii
Who Should Read This 25th Anniversary Edition? xix
Acknowledgments xxi

INTRODUCTION xxv
Directors in Jeopardy xxv
Actors: The Mysterious "Other" xxvi
An Invitation to Break Habit xxviii
How Actors Work Their Magic xxx
The Actor-Director Relationship xxxi
What Do Actors Want? xxxiii
What's In This Book xxxiv
Connection xxxvi

CHAPTER ONE:
RESULT DIRECTION AND QUICK FIXES 1
Result Direction: What the Hell Is It? (12+ Examples) 1
Quick Fixes 12
Verbs 13
Facts 20
Imagery 23
Metaphor or "as if" 25
Events 26
What It's About 27
Physical Tasks 28
Questions, Questions, Questions 29

Translation 31
Pro Tips 32
The Privacy Rule 35
The "Same Page" 35

CHAPTER TWO:
MOMENT BY MOMENT 36
Fear And Control 36
Risk 37
Unlikeable Characters 39
Honesty 40
In The Moment 42
The Character Has Free Will 44
The Character Has A Subconscious Mind 45
Permission To Fail 46
The Social Mask 46
Stop Doing It "Right" 50
Disobligation 51
Use It! 51
Commitment To Authenticity 52
The Notorious Insecurity of Actors 53
Exchange the Promise 53
Unrepeatable Moments 54
Directors Get to Be in the Moment, Too 55

CHAPTER THREE:
LISTENING AND TALKING 57
The What and Why of Listening 57
How Can a Director Tell If an Actor Is Listening? 60
Chemistry 62
Unselfish Actors 63
Damage Control 63
Special Situations 66

Listening Makes the Shots Work 68
Language Directors Can Use 69
Directors Should Listen, Too 70

CHAPTER FOUR:
ACTORS' CHOICES/DIRECTORS' TOOLS 72

Questions 74
Opposites 79
Mysterious Lines 81
The Technique of Three Possible 82
Judgment 83
Flaws and Likeability 85
The Verb Family: Intention, Objective, Spine, Need 87
Objective/Need 87
Intentions/Active Verbs 92
The Spine 99
Obstacle (The Stakes) 106
Imagery 109
Facts And Clues 115
The Timeline 115
Emotional History 116
Question Everything 117
Invented Facts and Off-Camera Scenes 118
The Moment Before 119
Adjustments: Metaphor; Analogy; "As If"; "What If?"; "It's Like When" 120
Subtext (Mantra or Inner Monologue) 125
Physical Life 126
Wardrobe 126
Objects 127
Gesture, Activities, Bits, Business 128
The Physical Is Emotional 129
Secrets 131
Why So Many Tools? 132

CHAPTER FIVE:
EMOTIONAL EVENT 134
Defining Emotional Event 134
Emotional Event As a Directing Tool 138
Find a Way In 140
So-Called Exposition Scenes 141
Emotional Event and Genre: It's All About the Relationship 141
What It's About 143
Make a List of Themes 146
Transitions and Through-Lines 148
Blocking 151
Learning How To Block 153
Does Everyone Have To Agree On the Emotional Event? 156
Emotional Events Must Happen In Real Time 158
Mindless Coverage (and Avoiding It) 158
Spine and Narrative Drive 159
Spine and Narrative Drive In Franchises 161
Director's Intention 163
Always Do the Right Thing 165
The Compass 165

CHAPTER SIX:
ACTORS' RESOURCES AND TRAINING 167
Memory or Personal Experience 167
Observation 169
Imagination 170
Research 172
Channeling 172
Meisner Technique 173
Living the Character's Experience 174
Concentration 176
Sensory Life 177

Shakespeare 179
Post-Stanislavsky 180
Working With Stars 182
Heart 183
Feelings 184

CHAPTER SEVEN:
SCRIPT ANALYSIS 185
Reading the Script 187
Stage Directions 188
The Charts and Guides 191
The Matrix 193
First Impressions: What I Love; My Reservations and Concerns 194
First Questions 195
"It's Just . . ." and "I Assume" 196
Pro Tip (for the Whole Script): Make Lists. Cut and Paste 196
Keep Reading the Script. Read It Aloud 198
Mysterious Lines & the Technique of Three Possible 199
Paraphrasing (Creating Inner Monologue) 205
Facts and Questions 206
Questions and More Questions 207
Research 210
Internal Research 210
Images and Associations 211
Ideas For Imaginative Backstory 211
What Just Happened 212
Objectives 213
What's At Stake? aka Issues 216
Active Verbs 217
Subtext 217
Obstacle 218

Adjustments 218
Beats 219
Blocking 220
Scene-Making 221
Make Events Happen With the Blocking 222
Get Ideas for Pacing. 223
Plot Event, Domestic Event, and Emotional Event 223
Cypher: One Last Mysterious Line 224
Finally: The Shape of the Relationships 225
Micro and Macro 227

CHAPTER EIGHT:
CASTING 229
Casting "Name" Actors. 229
Casting Directors 231
Casting From Auditions: Guidelines 232
Casting From Auditions: Procedure 236
Casting Non-Professional Actors 242
Casting From Self-Submitted Tapes 244
Pandemic and Connection (2020) 244

CHAPTER NINE:
REHEARSAL 247
Rehearsal: Pros and Cons 247
Director John Korty 249
Goals of Rehearsal 251
Skills and Tools of Rehearsal 254
Take—or Create—a Workshop 254
Overview of Necessary Skills 257
Ground Rules: Creating a Safe Space 258
Trust 259
Improvisation 260
Through-lines 266

Emotional Event 267
Mysterious Lines 267
Three Different Ways 267
Don't Frontload 268
Listen More than You Talk 269
Making Your Case 269
Pick Your Battles 270
Eye Contact 270
Getting Actors to Not Stop for "Mistakes" 271
Let the Actors Work 271
Learn to say, "Yes, and . . ." instead of "No, but . . ." 272
Other Exercises and Warm-Ups 272
Be Inventive. Go the Extra Mile. Think Outside the Box. 274
Resistances 275
Focus on the Work 276
Actors' Subtext 277
Making Moments Count: Blocking, Pacing, Scene-Making 279
Blocking 279
Blocking Templates 280
Pace: the Last Frontier 281
Making Moments Count 284
Objects, Activities, and Territories 285
Work in Steps 285
Working in Beats/Scene-Making 285
Nuts and Bolts 287
Finding Time for Rehearsal 287
How Long Should Rehearsal Be? 288
Get Organized 289
Notes to Bring to Rehearsal or the Set 290
Forms of Rehearsal 292
Meeting One-on-One with Principals 292
Full Cast Read-Through 296
Relationship Rehearsal 297
Scene Rehearsal for Most Professional Situations 298
Episodic Television 299

Working With Stars 302
Working With Non-Actors 304
More Examples of Rehearsal Language 306
Tips for Rehearsal Protocol 310
Sex, Violence, Pandemic 312
Zoom Rehearsals 314

CHAPTER TEN:
SHOOTING 318
If You've Had Rehearsal Before You Get to the Set 318
If You've Had No Rehearsal Before You Get to the Set 319
Guidelines for the Set 320

CHAPTER ELEVEN:
DIRECTING CHILDREN 332
Do You Like Kids? 332
Casting Young Roles 333
The Age of Eight Is a Game Changer 339
Kids and Line Readings 341
Meet Children Where They Are 342
Kids In Scenes With Adult Actors 344
Treat Young Actors As Equals 346
How Young Actors Approach Their Craft 348
Traumatic Material 349
Young Teens 351
Older Teens 351
Commit To Them 352
What About Older Actors? 353

CHAPTER TWELVE:
COMEDY 355
Faster, Louder, Funnier 356
More Principles of Comedy 358

EPILOGUE 361

APPENDIX A 365
A: Verbs—Short List, Expanded 365
B: Verbs—Longer List, Grouped by Emotional Category 368
C: Script Analysis Guide for Directors 371
D: Script Analysis List of Topics 375
E: Script Analysis Addendum for Actors 376
F: Text of *The Matrix*, Scene 74 378
G: Billy Ray's 3x5 card 381

INDEX OF SELECTED NAMES AND TITLES 382

ABOUT THE AUTHOR 391

CHAPTER ONE

Result Direction and Quick Fixes

Result Direction: What the Hell Is It? (12+ Examples)

The biggest complaint I hear from actors is that directors don't know what they want. This may come as a surprise, because most directors think they have a clear picture in their minds of how they want the movie to look and sound.

While reading a script, most people project a miniature movie version of it on the inside of their foreheads. They fantasize the faces of actors they hope will play the roles, they see the facial expressions, they hear the inflections of the lines. No matter how many times they read the script, they hear and see the same line readings, the same raised eyebrow or frown that they have pictured from the first. They come to think of this as their "vision" of the script.

This is a passive approach to script-reading. It limits your ideas and hobbles your imagination. It denies any life to the characters beyond the four edges of the script's pages. It's like insisting that the earth is as flat and four-cornered as a viewing screen and that people or characters disappear when they walk off the edge. It causes you to look at a line and say to yourself, "How can this be made dramatic?" or "How can this be made funny?" rather than, "What clues does this give me to what the movie is about and what the characters are doing to solve their predicaments?" It may cause you

to make artistic choices based on what you know about other movies, rather than on what you know about life.

This mistaken way of reading a script often leads to directors using what is known as "result direction." A director may have labored over financing, three-act structure, storyboards—and still not have done the homework that will help her communicate her ideas to actors. Directors, who tend to feel that their result-oriented ideas are very exact, may be unaware that actors—who want to please the director but need to make *playable choices*—can experience result direction as vague, general, and confusing instead of specific and clear.

Terms like *result direction* and *playable choices* are slippery and may be used differently by different people. What is result-oriented direction? I'm going to take the plunge with thirteen examples:

1) "Can you make it more quirky?"

Describing the *effect* you want actors to have on the audience is a perfect example of directing by asking for a *result*. Instructions of this ilk—such as, "This scene should be funny," or "I need you to be more dangerous," or "Can you give her an epic quality?"—cause an actor's heart to sink. The director wants her to do something different from what she is doing—what can it be? If the actor asks for clarification, the director may go blank and simply repeat himself: "You know, *more quirky*." From this point, the actor-director relationship dissolves into a guessing game, because the direction is vague and general. The actor tries something—is this it? Often, it still isn't. Oftener still, the director really didn't know in the first place what he wanted or how to recognize it. The actor's performance may have deteriorated because she has begun to watch herself, to *get in her head*. It is death to an actor's gifts to put her concentration on the *effect* she is having on the audience.

Describing to the actors the "mood" of a scene—for example, sultry, alienated, electric—can be problematic for similar reasons. Actors who try to *play a mood* can end up evoking exactly the

opposite of what the director was hoping for: efforts to "look" serious often produce an unintentionally comic effect; efforts to "be" light and frothy can prove heavy-handed. Their attention has been wrongly placed and thus, their eagerness to produce the desired effect can cause them to concentrate on the effort itself. Consequently, *the effort itself* is the effect that finally reads.

2) **"When you say the line, 'You always do that,' don't put the emphasis on 'always'—instead hit the word 'do.' So, not 'You *always* do that,' but like this: 'You always *do* that.'"**

This is called giving the actor a *line reading*. That is, telling the actor what inflection or cadence to give a line. For instance, if the line is, "Please help me," there are a number of different line readings, each completely reasonable. Like these examples: "*Please* help me," or "Please *help* me," or "Please help *me*." And each different line reading means something different.

What's wrong with giving line readings? Well, worst-case scenario, an inexperienced actor might try to obey you and repeat back the line with the new inflection, but without any life behind it. An experienced actor, of course, will look for a way to give it life—that's her job. But sometimes the line reading makes no sense to the actor. If she asks you what it means, you want to be able to do more to clarify the direction than just repeating the line reading over and over.

If you need an actor to make an adjustment to her performance, it's more helpful to communicate to her the *meaning* or subtext of the line, not the inflection or result. The most dangerous signal conveyed by a director who gives line readings is that he may not even know what the line means, what the *intention* of the character is, or what the scene is about.

3) **"Can you take it down?" Or, "Can you give it more energy?"**

There are directors who seem to have only these two generic directions in their toolkit. When directors rely entirely on these two

phrases—"more energy" or "take it down"—over and over in situations that are not at all alike, actors may start to feel that the director does not really know what she is talking about and that the direction has become a string of empty clichés. Worse yet, it may mean that the director is not able to recognize good acting when she sees it. I have seen actors do brave, scary things, and yet afterwards all the director says is that she wants it "bigger."

Of course, sometimes "take it down" or "give it more energy" is a perfectly fine direction. If an experienced actor has overcooked his performance a smidge, maybe pushed a bit and stepped over the line into overacting, he appreciates getting the heads-up to "take it down." If his performance is flat or not making the scene work—in other words, if it needs more energy—he wants to be advised of that; he will respond by making a different *playable subtext choice*. Don't get me wrong: If an actor could do better, he wants to be told!

But less experienced actors can fall into bad traps. An inexperienced actor may interpret "Take it down" as a request to say the line in a monotone. Being asked for "more energy" or to "ramp it up" or "punch it up" can cause them to add emphasis to the uninspired line reading they have already frozen into their performance. Inexperienced actors are vulnerable—don't sabotage them with vague, unhelpful instructions.

4) "You need to get angry on this line."

I've been warming up with a couple of examples of result direction that you may already be familiar with. You probably know it's not cool to give line readings or tell the actor to "be funnier." Now I'm getting to the more complicated stuff—emotions.

Emotions are what it's all about. Storytelling exists to tap into the emotions of the audience, and the way to do that is for the director and actors to access their own emotions. The film *Edward Scissorhands* endures because it goes deep into the pain, sadness, anger, and longing that has been felt by any human being who has ever been isolated, misunderstood, or lonely.

Don't be afraid of feeling.

But. Emotionally investing in your story and all your characters is not the same as deciding what every character feels at a given moment. Telling the actors what their characters should be feeling—angry, disappointed, worried, annoyed, excited, in love, frightened, resentful, disapproving—is a very usual way that direction is given. Here's the problem with it: As soon as an actor *tries* to have a feeling or manufactures a feeling on demand, he looks like an actor, not a real person. People in real life often find our feelings are *obstacles* to what we want; we would prefer *not* to feel nervous at an important meeting, *not* to feel upset when an ex-lover and their new spouse appear unexpectedly at a party, *not* to feel angry when our loved ones disappoint us.

To be playable, a choice must be *choosable*, and *we do not choose our feelings*. This idea can be hard to take in, but I want you to think about it: *we don't get to decide how to feel.* For some reason, we humans don't much like this about our lives. Mediocre actors, as well as much of the general population, go to great lengths to make the world believe they feel something that they don't actually feel. But most of the time no one is fooled. Feelings can be hidden or repressed, but we can't selectively shut down just one feeling. When one feeling is held back, all feeling gets shut down.

Good actors are emotionally free and available to many subtleties of feeling. Emotion and impulse are the center of the actor's world. But feelings are pesky critters, cropping up inconveniently—then disappearing just when you want them. The thing both terrible and wonderful about feelings is that they change. You have seen it in real life—a person can be crying one minute and laughing the next. The truth is, the more you let yourself feel whatever you are actually feeling, the more available you are to a new feeling. For actors, this goes double.

It can have a shrinking effect on actors to tell them their emotions are wrong. When actors are told to have less feeling, they may drop out emotionally—and the scene can then become flat and

lifeless. When they are told to have more feeling, they may fall into pushing, or underlining—overacting.

5) **"You need to react to her with more shock and anger."**

An extension of telling the actor what emotion to have is telling him what *reaction* to have. In real life we may *wish* we could plan our reactions—we may wish we could react calmly to bad news; we may wish we could laugh merrily when a client or boss tells an unfunny joke—but it's a fact of life that such disconcerting incidents take us by surprise. In a script, these surprises and reactions are the story's *emotional events*—and the characters don't know they are coming. The actors, having read the script, do know what's going to happen to their characters—and what they are going to do or say when it does. We want the actors' reactions to be not preprogramed but spontaneous and idiosyncratic. That's how their performances give scenes the texture of real life.

6) **"When the scene starts, A is worried because B is late. A is relieved when B arrives, but then disappointed because B hasn't got the money, and then B realizes that A has become suspicious that B might be holding out on him."**

This is what I call a fully loaded emotional map, outlining all the feelings and reactions you have decided the characters are supposed to have in the scene. It's nothing more than a tedious regurgitation of the dialogue and plot. Sadly, it commonly passes for an explanation of the characters' psychology and understanding of what the script is about.

At first glance, emotional maps look innocuous enough. You may be asking yourself, what could be wrong with this? How else would you describe what happens in a scene? Everybody talks about characters this way, don't they? In fact, people in real life talk about each other like this too. It's called gossip. Like gossip, emotional maps are not only tedious and long-winded but addictive. Director and actors talk a scene to death—going down

convoluted rabbit holes, until whatever genuine emotional connection the actors originally responded to has been rendered thoroughly cerebral. It's the surest way to drain a scene or characterization of all its life.

Don't forget, directors need always to look for ways to save time. Endless abstract discussions lead, finally, to *analysis paralysis*. When actors try to follow an emotional map, the performance degenerates into an intellectualized connect-the-dots drawing—contrived and predictable. It can't flow, because it has no *through-line*. It can't advance the story because it has no sense of *emotional event*.

The best direction is simple and to the point. There are more dynamic, briefer, more muscular ways to evoke characterizations than the convolutions of emotional maps. I want you to practice and learn them. Elia Kazan said a director's job is to *turn psychology into behavior*. How to do this? Focus on the *relationships* between the characters: pose questions about their *emotional history*, consider *choices* about their *needs* from each other, create the *emotional events* of scenes—rather than be satisfied with reductive emotional maps.

7) **"He's a punk." "She's self-destructive." "He's stupid." "A loser." "A bitch." "A poseur."**

These are negative *judgments* on the character. Good actors *never* judge their character. If the actor is not on the character's side, who will be? No one is born bad. Like people, characters become who they are because of their needs, the things that happen to them, and the decisions they make. Neither writer, director, nor actor should judge the character, who, like all of us, has both good and bad sides. The *audience* gets to decide which character is weak or strong, ambitious, lazy, etc.

Audiences love suspense. The craving to know *what happens next* makes them lean into the story. Even if we know that the hero is going to win or the lovers are going to live happily ever after.

Even if it's a "character piece" and all its events are interior, private. When the actor telegraphs to the audience thus: "I'm the good guy," "I'm the loser," or "I'm the villain"—he is playing a caricature. Who can care what happens to him?

It goes without saying that serious drama loses any opportunity for insight or revelation when good and evil are portrayed without ambiguity. Villains portrayed as recognizably human, like Ralph Fiennes's Nazi commandant in *Schindler's List*, are far more frightening than cardboard cutouts. A main character with human flaws, like Sigourney Weaver's Ripley in *Alien*, is more relatable for the audience than a formulaic, perfect hero. If you are directing live-action characters based on the DC or Marvel universes, it's as important to find a central humanity to the character as it is when directing naturalistic drama. Heath Ledger as the Joker in *The Dark Knight* showed us it's possible to meet the demands of genre without caricature. He forever raised the bar.

It's extremely disappointing for a good actor to work with a director who judges the characters. If directors want to have a meaningful conversation with an actor, they need to have unlocked ways not to judge *any* of the characters—this should be a central element of their preparation, their *script analysis*. Instead of judging, the director should approach each character with openness, and—dare I say it—compassion. When the director speaks to each actor, take the side of that character. My personal motto for connecting myself to characters who do things that I believe I would never do in life is this: "This character is me with a little worse luck."

One last, serious warning: If an inexperienced or untrained actor is given direction that is judgmental toward their character—because that actor may not have been trained in techniques with which to translate poor direction into a playable choice—I can just about promise you the results will be disappointing, if not disastrous.

8) "This is how I see the character . . ."

Labeling character traits is something you might recognize from real-life families: one sibling labeled the smart one, one the flaky one, one the responsible one, one the difficult one. While these shorthand descriptions may not be negative—may even be meant as compliments—they are never the whole story.

Narrative filmmakers routinely describe to actors "what the character is like"—haughty, tormented, awkward, fierce. Look, I'm not saying these labels are wrong—tormented people surely exist. I am asking that you *not stop* at such quick branding. The character is not an abstraction that the actor must "become." The character is an active human being with emotional history, with needs—who has free will, who takes chances, who makes mistakes.

9) "Can you play him aggressive, but pleasant?"

Try to avoid describing characters the way that some people describe fine wine. "The character is frightened, but determined." Or, "defensive, yet vulnerable," "cynical, yet caring," "catatonic, yet curious."

Directors mean well—and actors themselves may talk about their characters this way. Both directors and actors may think that a description like this calls attention to the complexity of the character. People *are* complex and it is exactly my goal to allow the characters to have as much complexity as actual people. However, making a long list of contradictory labels does not accomplish complexity.

There isn't only one way of creating complexity in a character—after all, it's complex! Actors who successfully bring to life complex and contradictory characters create rich and detailed *layers*. Just like people, characters may *say* one thing while *doing* the exact *opposite*. Think of a person who says, "I'm sorry" while glaring at you. Or—characters may *alternate* what they are doing—for instance, shifting their *intention* from *punishing* to *apologizing* and back again to *punishing*—with lightning speed. But describing the behavior as "defensive, yet vulnerable" is lazy. And inattentive to the behavior of real human beings.

10) "Let's give [this character] a hostile edge."

I was taught by my teacher Jean Shelton never to *"play attitude."* When you limit your script analysis to a quick psychological sketch of this sort—that the character has a *wary* attitude towards his brother, a *tender* attitude towards his sister, a *hostile* attitude towards his father—you limit your imagination.

Now, describing this hypothetical family the way I did just now would be better than dismissing the family as "dysfunctional." It's okay to note that it sounds like a dysfunctional family—but *don't stop* with that generality. Go deeper. Ask *questions* about the family's *emotional history*: Where is the mother? Is there a history of abuse, neglect, or addiction? What has the father done to lose his son's trust?

Ideas for *objectives* may come out of speculation around these questions. For instance, perhaps our main character is driven by a need *to protect the sister from the brother and father*. A spine so primal can sustain an actor's performance and create relationships of emotional depth and power.

11) "I want more energy, but not hysterical energy." Or, "The character is grossed out, but not *too* grossed out."

Actors are not machines. You cannot dial a performance the way you dial levels on equipment. The *dialing* result direction drives actors to despair and makes them feel that no matter what they do, it will be wrong. Attempts to dial performances are assaults on an actor's connection to the moment. Experienced actors will do their best, but over time will become less interested in what the director has to say. A director who gives *dialing* direction is sending a clear signal to the actors that he is clueless about the character's interior life—and that he has done zero script analysis preparation. I can't help feeling that *dialing* is the very worst result direction.

12) "You need to have a smirk on your face, because the script says so."

Sometimes the script itself seems to be giving an emotional result. Sometimes a character has a line of dialogue declaring his emotional state—such as, "I'm a callous person," or, "I'm frightened." Or another character has a line: "You look so smug." There can be stage directions or parentheticals in the script describing the character's emotions, such as, "disappointed" or "her voice quivering with rage." The actor whose character's emotional state is being described in the text (whether in dialogue or stage direction) may feel obligated to produce that emotion. Many actors ignore—and may literally cross out with a Sharpie—the emotional parentheticals, because creating the emotional subtext is the very province of the actors. (It's a lot like the way directors typically disregard suggestions by the writer for camera angles.)

Don't think of the script as giving emotional instructions. Instead look for the emotional *clues* to the subtext. Actors already torture themselves with worry and stress over whether or not they have the "right" emotion. As soon as they start envisioning the characters in terms of what emotion they "should" be having, their emotional life is dying a little death. Directors can help support them in finding an emotional life that is honest and original by *questioning* the emotional-result stage directions in the script.

13) Bonus example! "Can you split the difference between take 3 and take 5?" "Do it the same but one year younger." "Can you play it more anecdotally?"

These are actual quotes that have been reported to me from actual sets. I call this "ridiculous direction."

Alright. Okay. Who knows? Maybe saying, "Do it the same, but one year younger," will mean something to a particular actor and do just the trick.

But—seriously. It. Might. Not. You need other options.

Quick Fixes

There are powerful tools ready to come to your rescue. I call them *Quick Fixes* because when you know how to use them, they're more efficient than lengthy emotional mapping or facile pop-psychology explanations, and more effective than result-oriented generalities about the characters' character traits or emotional states.

I also call them Quick Fixes because I don't want you to get discouraged about how depressingly familiar you may have found the list of result directions earlier in this chapter. And, okay, let's face it—I wanted you to read this chapter and I knew one titled "Quick Fixes" would be the first thing you'd read, no matter where I placed it in the book, so I figured I might as well put it at the beginning.

These "quick fixes" are not a cheat sheet, but a sophisticated set of *tools* to create believable behavior. To quote directing coach Adrienne Weiss, "An actor shouldn't do something unless something makes him do it. To strengthen a reaction, make what's *pushing* the actor/character stronger." That's what the tools do—address the stimulus, create a *reason* for the character's behavior.

I shouldn't give you the impression that result direction never works, because sometimes it does. When a director has a deep level of trust with an actor, they can probably say just about anything to each other. But how do you get to that trust? I recommend this path: genuine curiosity about what makes actors tick, real concern for emotional honesty from your actors, love for your characters, and an interest in revealing truths about human behavior. Actors pick up on all that.

Along the way, the tools will help and support you. Here they are:

- *verbs* (aka *intention* or *objective* or *need*);
- *facts* (aka *emotional history* or *backstory*);
- *subtext imagery*;
- *emotional event*;
- *obstacle*;

- *metaphor, the "as if"*;
- *physical life*;
- and—*questions*.

These powerful tools are keys to the inner life of the story and its characters. Like result-oriented generalities, the *tools* can stop working unexpectedly—*but they are less likely to*. And if they do stop working, the situation is less hopeless, because *verbs, facts, images, events, metaphor, physical life, and questions*, in addition to being helpful language for direction, are useful *script analysis* tools. They open up your imagination. Once you are alive and active in the subtext of the script, you *will have* new ideas—this I promise you. The tools turn ideas into events and psychology into behavior. They are active and dynamic rather than static, sensory rather than intellectual, specific rather than general, and above all, emotional rather than abstract. Okay. Let's jump in.

Verbs

You may have noticed that many of the examples of result direction involve adjectives—*be quirky, be funny, be dangerous, be sexy, be sad, be angry, be defensive, be suspicious, be awkward, be tormented*. A powerful way to be less result-oriented is to get excited about *verbs* and to incorporate more of them in your communication. Verbs (like *demand, beg, seduce, blame*) describe experience and are more active than adjectives. Some of my directing students tell me that *verbs* have changed their lives.

Here's an invitation that may seem at first burdensome, but I promise you, will be liberating: *get specific*. For example, instead of describing a character by saying he is "being defensive," let's see if we can *translate* that generality into a more specific verb. For now, let's consult the Short List of Verbs, in Appendix A. You might say that the right verb is not on that list. You might want to say that the appropriate verb translation for "being defensive" is *to defend* or *to protect* or *to deflect*.

Totally cool. These are verbs and they might work; I don't rule them out. But I've got to be honest. When I think about the verbs *to defend* or *to protect* or *to deflect*—those verbs feel wimpy to me and I want to keep looking for a *bolder choice*. What about *complain, belittle*, or *warn?* Strong, active verbs.

I found those ideas by thinking about the defensive behaviors I have seen in life (including my own). When people are being defensive, it's often because information is coming at them that they don't like, or don't want to face—information that impairs their self-image. Each "defensive" person has her particular *tactics* to take attention off the information she perceives as an attack. She might *complain* about being picked on unfairly; she might *belittle* the source of the information; she might *warn* the person conveying the information not to persist. She might even *accuse* the other person of something entirely irrelevant, in order to take the conversation off-topic.

I don't claim that the Short List of Verbs (or even the longer list, in Appendix B) comprises all of human behavior—they're examples, to orient you to the world of verbs.

Verbs are a quick fix, but they are also central to the basic understanding of a character—that the behavior of characters (and people) arises from their *needs*. I use the term Verb Family to introduce a constellation of tools: *verb* (or *intention*), *objective* (or *need*, *through-line*), and *spine*. The Verb Family is valuable for creating a characterization, as well as for structuring a scene. Here are a few examples of how a member of the Verb Family can function as an alternative to common result directions.

Use an active verb instead of an emotion.

A strong, active verb creates an emotional response between characters. That's its job. "To confront" is an example of an active verb. It has an emotional component in that being confronted—for instance, over lying or cheating—has a serious emotional effect on the person being confronted. And—it has a serious

emotional effect on the person doing the confronting! I mean, have you ever confronted someone for their deliberate cruelty? Can you imagine how doing such a stressful thing would churn your emotions? (I'm talking about face-to-face, not on Twitter. The anonymity of social media makes confrontation feel easy, but in real life it's not.)

Can you see how "to accuse" or "to punish" is more powerful than "to become angry"? The word "become" is a verb, but it's not active toward another person. Active verbs focus each actor's attention on their scene partner—on the effect they are having on their scene partner—instead of on their own performance. Thus the actors are *engaged* with each other, they are *listening*. When the actors affect each other, *something happens*. If one character is *begging* and the other one is *ridiculing*, something will happen! Someone will get hurt—or won over—or maybe something else no one expected. These are the *emotional events*. Now you've got drama. Or comedy. The verbs work for both.

We cannot decide how to feel; we can decide what to *do*. Verbs are experiential, dynamic, and playable rather than descriptive and result-oriented.

A couple of examples of translations from emotional result to verb:

- Instead of the adjective *vicious*, the verb *to belittle*.
- Instead of adjectives *weak* or *desperate*, the verb *to beg* or *to plead*.

Use a verb instead of an attitude.

Examples of translating *attitudes* to *verbs* or *objectives* kind of make themselves:

- Instead of *an accusatory attitude*, the verb *to accuse*.
- Instead of *a threatening attitude*, the verb *to threaten*.
- Instead of *a mocking tone*, the verb *to mock*.
- Instead of *a friendly attitude*, the objective *to make friends*.
- Instead of *cheerful*, the objective *to cheer the other character up*.

Those are simple ones. Some you have to think about a bit. For example, instead of *hostile*, you might consider the objective *to make her feel unwelcome* or *make her feel uncomfortable*.

Superior actors will not be harmed by your using verbs instead of adjectives and less experienced actors may very well be rescued from disaster. An actor who is floundering may find the right track. A scene may come alive right before your eyes! So instead of asking an actor to "play it sexy" (the result), you might suggest that he "flirt" with her (verb); instead of asking an actor to "be angrier," you might suggest that she "accuse" or "punish" him.

Please do not think of me as the language police! If "a mocking tone" sounds more natural than "to mock," go for it. I want you to become invested in something more important than just using "correct" instead of "incorrect" language. I want you to understand that what is *happening* between characters is more significant than line readings. What matters—however you describe it—is the *intention* underneath, the *need* for each character to have an effect on the other characters.

For the director, the shift from attitude to verb looks like a small one—but really it's a big one. It means thinking of the story as a network of *relationships* instead of a collection of performances. This simple but sophisticated shift to your understanding of storytelling will advance your skills more than you can imagine. Because it helps you determine and recognize *emotional events*. Emotional events tell your story.

It's time for me to mention that when I say *suggest* such and such direction, I really do mean suggest. This is what I like to call the *language of permission*. For instance, "What do you think about this thought I had?" Or, "I was wondering whether this idea might be worth trying . . ." The *language of permission* is not about diplomacy—it's about honesty. If a director has an idea, even one that she is passionately committed to, no one really knows whether it will work until the actors try it.

Use a verb instead of "take it down."

Actors actually hear directors say things like, "Can you take it down by about 90%?" Can you hear how hard it would be to interpret this direction—other than to assume the director hates everything about you? It can sap actors' energy to be constantly told to "take it down" instead of a more specific direction. It can make them feel that you don't care if they commit, that you don't want them to engage.

Verbs can help. You may notice, though, that it will take more thought on your part to articulate precisely what it is you want using verbs. This is why you need to prepare! Yes, I am advocating homework, but the extra mental exertion is good for you! Directing is not supposed to be easy. Asking an actor to *coax* rather than *demand* might be another way of getting them to "take it down." Do you want the actor to punish? To warn? To complain? Each of those verbs would give a different level of intensity to a scene or moment; *punish* might be the most intense and *complain* the least intense. But—you can't be sure until they try it! It's not a chemistry formula, where "X" milliliters of hydrochloric acid combined with "Y" milliliters of bleach will always turn the litmus paper a certain color.

When director Courtney Hunt shot the indie film *Frozen River*, she had already worked with her lead, Melissa Leo, on a short film; she knew that Leo would bring a lot of energy to the set. While shooting *Frozen River*, instead of telling Leo to "take it down," Hunt said in an interview that she would ask Leo to "confess it." This is a brilliant way to adjust a performance! It not only prevents the performance from going over the top, it supports the deep vulnerability of this lost and haunted character.

Use a verb instead of "give it more energy."

Choosing stronger verbs is great for creating more energetic performances. Look at the difference in energy between *to convince* and *to accuse*. In real life, the verb *to convince* is more common than the verb

to accuse—and for good reason. In the business and social world, *convincing* someone to admit they lied is more diplomatic, and probably more effective, than *accusing* them of lying. But for drama—or comedy—the more heightened verb, *to accuse*, can take the scene to another level. Vivid verbs like *accuse* or *provoke* or *seduce* may be counterproductive in real life—but in narrative fiction, they are more exciting than the socially acceptable verbs like convince.

Use a verb instead of describing "what the character is like" or "how I see the character."

We are what we do. I had an acting teacher who used to roar at us, "If a man is standing on his head in the middle of the road, nobody asks if he's the type!" At the time his statement (which he repeated often, at full volume) was a riddle to me; I pondered it for a long time without understanding. What I know now years later is that actors and directors waste energy and time gossiping about the characters, arguing over whether the character "would do" such and such a thing. *If he does it, he would do it!*

Actors sometimes resist this idea. You'll hear them say: "My character would never manipulate—she's too nice." Or, "My character wouldn't flirt—he's uptight about his sexuality." News flash: Uptight people flirt! Nice people manipulate! Proud people beg! Shy people brag! People are complex! In real life, we do lots of things that are inexplicable to others—and even to ourselves. Actors and directors who get stuck in "what the character is like" miss entirely what a tangle of opposites humans really are. You don't get to the complexity of a character by indulging in *analysis paralysis*—it only piles convolution upon convolution, psychologizing the character to death.

One way to create complexity in characters is to remind yourself that human behavior is often irrational—possibly more often than not. Another way is to understand what makes a character complex is to notice that he does different things at different times. Robert Downey, Jr. is a master at this; he can change intentions (verbs) in the wink of an eye—he is able to charm, challenge,

whine, demand, seduce—not all at once (although it may seem like it)—but *one at a time in extremely quick succession*. This makes his characters complex, unpredictable—and quirky.

Don't waste time wrestling over some abstract concept of what the character's personality is. Go for the behavior.

Use a verb instead of a judgment.

Instead of denouncing a character as manipulative, give some thought to the specific behaviors of a manipulative person. For example, the mother, played by Mo'Nique, in the 2009 film *Precious*. I expect that many of us might view Mary as manipulative. But let's go deeper than that negative generality and instead break down—deconstruct—that judgment into specific behaviors or *intentions*. Here are some verbs I thought of: Mary *demands*, she *goads*, she definitely *punishes*—but she also *sweet-talks* and *cajoles*; she even *begs*. Not all at once—different verbs in different situations. She's complicated! More complicated than her luckless daughter, played by Gabourey Sidibe, who has one single need: to make someone, anyone, love her.

Use a verb instead of a line reading.

During your script analysis, you can think up ways to translate the line reading in your head into a verb. The line reading, "*Please* help me" might carry the intention *to beg*; the line reading, "Please *help* me," the intention *to demand*; the line reading, "Please help *me*," perhaps the intention *to complain*. But when you're out of time, don't beat yourself up. Just remember that when you have the urge to demonstrate a line reading for an actor, what you really want is a particular *intention*, or verb. If you can't think of any other way of communicating what you want than a line reading, it can help if you say something like, "I know it sounds like I'm giving a line reading, but there's an intention I'm looking for and I can't think of the verb."